

Entregar después de la segunda escucha (fase andamiada).

Ava: Last night I opened my refrigerator door, closed it, and opened it again. About fifteen times. Standing there in the dark.

Andrew: Should I be worried about you?

Ava: I wanted the sound. That soft thump when the door pulls itself shut. Something holds that door, and it is not a lock and it is not a handle.

Andrew: It is the rubber. That soft grey part around the edge.

Ava: Inside the rubber there is a thin magnetic strip. It runs all the way around the door. It has been there your whole life and you have never once thought about it.

Andrew: Welcome to In the Lab FM, by the way. And I always thought it was suction. Cold air inside, small vacuum, door sticks.

Ava: I said that for years too. Then I found out why it is a magnet and felt ridiculous.

Andrew: So why a magnet? Why not a normal latch?

Ava: Because of something sad. Old refrigerators shut with a heavy latch, like a car door. People left broken ones out in yards. Children climbed in to play, and the latch did not open from the inside.

Andrew: Oh no.

Ava: In nineteen fifty-six a law in the United States said refrigerator doors had to open from the inside. The magnetic strip was the answer. Strong enough to hold the cold in, weak enough that a small hand can push it open. That makes it perfectly safe.

Andrew: So the quiet thump in my kitchen is the shape of a law from nineteen fifty-six.

Ava: Every night. And nobody ever mentions it.

Andrew: Alright. My magnet story is four hundred years older than yours. In the year sixteen hundred an English doctor published a book about magnets.

Ava: A doctor. Not a sailor.

Andrew: William Gilbert. Doctor to Queen Elizabeth the First. And sailors had crossed oceans with compasses for centuries with nobody knowing why the needle moved.

Ava: Nobody?

Andrew: The popular idea was a mountain of magnetic rock somewhere in the north. Other people said the Pole Star pulled it.

Ava: So the tool worked and the explanation was a story.

Andrew: Exactly. Gilbert carved a ball out of magnetic rock and called it a little Earth. Then he walked a tiny compass across the surface and wrote down everything the needle did.

Ava: And?

Andrew: It behaved like a ship compass at sea. It even tipped downward as he moved it north, the way a real compass tips. So he said the thing nobody had said. The Earth itself is a magnet. Not a mountain. Not a star. The whole planet.

Ava: That is completely different from what everyone believed.

Andrew: Completely different. And he tested it instead of arguing about it.

Ava: Can I ask a boring question? Did it help anyone? The ships already worked.

Andrew: Not for a long time. No.

Ava: Then here is my unpopular opinion. I want scientists working on water, on medicine, on what people need this year. Budgets are small. Curiosity is lovely, but somebody has to fix the pump.

Andrew: Everything in this room came from somebody who was only curious. Gilbert was not fixing a pump. He was playing with a rock.

Ava: That argument is too easy. You pick the curiosity that paid off and quietly forget the thousand that went nowhere.

Andrew: That is fair. I do that. But nobody can tell which is which in advance. That is the whole problem.

Ava: Hm. I will give you half of that.

Andrew: I will take the half. Especially since my voice is reaching you through a magnet right now.

Ava: How?

Andrew: The signal from your phone runs into a tiny coil of wire. For a fraction of a second that coil turns into a magnet.

Ava: Wait. It becomes a magnet and then stops being one?

Andrew: Thousands of times a second. The coil sits beside a permanent magnet, so it gets pushed and pulled, and it drags a thin sheet with it. The sheet shakes the air. That is my voice.

Ava: Every word I hear is a small piece of metal being shoved around. And my earbuds are the size of a bean.

Andrew: A weak magnet, though. Two fingers beat your fridge door. But the one inside a hospital scanner is incredibly strong. Staff keep every piece of metal out of that room. A steel chair does not slide across the floor. It flies.

Ava: That image is staying with me.

Andrew: What stays with me is Gilbert. His real question was not how magnets work. It was why everybody believed something nobody had ever tested.

Ava: And I trust ten invisible things before breakfast. The door holds. The compass on my phone points north. My voice comes out of a bean.

Andrew: So what are we all sure about today, with nothing underneath it?

Ava: Next time we take a machine that made a decision nobody could explain.

Andrew: Which might be the same question in a different coat.

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Ava: So I got home on Tuesday. I showed this man my holiday photos, and the first thing he said was, congratulations, you just helped ruin a small town.

Andrew: I did not say ruin. I said drowning. Some towns are drowning in visitors, and one of them has a name I cannot get out of my head. Playa Serena.

Ava: Welcome to In the Lab FM. I have sand in my shoes and, apparently, a guilty conscience.

Andrew: You had a beautiful week. I am not attacking your week.

Ava: You are attacking my week a little.

Andrew: Fine. I think there is a difference between visiting a place and arriving in it like weather. Fifty of you, then five hundred, then five thousand.

Ava: Hold on, according to the World Travel and Tourism Council, about one in ten jobs worldwide is connected to travel and tourism. One in ten. Those are not decorations. Those are salaries.

Andrew: I never said they were not.

Ava: And the data shows the scale of it. One point four billion arrivals counted at borders in a single year.

Andrew: You say that number like it is a trophy, and it seems to me it is a warning.

Ava: Then tell me about Playa Serena. You say the name like it is a wound.

Andrew: It was a fishing town. Two streets, a lighthouse, nothing famous. Then a photographer posted a picture of that lighthouse at sunset, and the picture travelled further than anyone in the town ever had.

Ava: And it became well-known.

Andrew: Very well-known. Within two years there were tour buses on a street built for donkeys. Then low-cost flights started landing at the airport an hour away, and on a good weekend the town held more visitors than residents.

Ava: That is money arriving.

Andrew: That is money arriving. And then the prices went up, fast. There is a woman called Marta Rivas. Her family cooked fish on the corner by the church for forty years. Her rent tripled in three summers.

Ava: Did she close?

Andrew: She closed. Her son Beto works in the hotel that stands where the old market was. He cannot afford to live in the town, so he lives forty minutes inland and takes the five forty bus every morning.

Ava: Wait, seriously? He commutes into his own hometown?

Andrew: Every day. He serves breakfast on the street where he learned to ride a bike. And clearly something is broken when that is normal.

Ava: Okay. Let me say your side back to you, so I am not being unfair. You are saying the money is real, but it does not stay with the people who were already there. It pushes them out of their own streets.

Andrew: Yes. That is exactly it.

Ava: Right. So here is my question. Before that photograph, what was Beto's plan?

Andrew: Meaning what?

Ava: Meaning young people were already leaving towns like that, and not because of tourists. My grandmother's village emptied out in the nineteen eighties. No tourist ever went there. There is nobody left to push out.

Andrew: That is a fair hit. I will take it. I was comparing Playa Serena today with a Playa Serena that never existed, quiet and poor and happy.

Ava: Thank you.

Andrew: But then look at who owns Beto's hotel. Not one family from that town. The argument is not tourists or no tourists. It is who holds the key to the money.

Ava: That I will give you. And that is why cities are pushing back. Venice banned day visitors, right?

Andrew: Not banned. On busy days they charge day visitors a fee to come in. It started at five euros.

Ava: Five euros? I have been telling people at dinner that Venice closed its doors. For about a year. So I had that wrong.

Andrew: Barcelona went further. The mayor announced a plan to end tourist apartment rentals in the city by twenty twenty-eight.

Ava: See, that I like. That is a city choosing. And my hotel was eco-friendly. Solar panels, no plastic bottles, little cards about the towels.

Andrew: Was the water eco-friendly? Honest question. Where does a hotel pool get its water in a dry summer?

Ava: I do not know. That is annoying. I genuinely do not know.

Andrew: I do not either, and I am not innocent. I flew three thousand kilometres in March to spend four days with my sister, and I would do it again tomorrow.

Ava: So what, we stop going?

Andrew: No. I do not have a clean answer. I just keep seeing Beto on that bus at five forty in the dark.

Ava: And I keep thinking he might have been on a bus anyway. Going the other way, and not coming back.

Andrew: Both of those can be true at the same time. That is the part I hate.

Ava: Next week, a broken machine. But tell me one thing first. If nobody had ever posted that photograph, would Beto still live in Playa Serena?

Andrew: I do not know. Ask me at five forty, in the dark, on that bus.

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Ava: Forty seconds. That is how long the new software needed to finish a job that used to take Efren a whole morning.

Andrew: And Efren had been doing that same job, every working day, for eleven years.

Ava: This is In the Lab FM. Ana here, with Beto, and a job that disappeared without a sound.

Andrew: Efren is my cousin. He lives in a small town called Santa Rosa del Pino, and he made technical drawings for a workshop that builds metal shelves.

Ava: The same drawings every day?

Andrew: Different sizes, same shapes. He drew the brackets, he checked the measurements, he sent the file to the cutting machine. Then he did it again.

Ava: And one day the boss bought a program.

Andrew: In March. You type the sizes into a table and the drawings come out. Forty seconds. Efren could not keep up with it. Nobody could.

Ava: This is exactly what scares me. He did not do anything wrong. He did not get lazy.

Andrew: Not at all. But here is the thing. Repetitive tasks are the easiest for machines to take over, and his day was mostly the same steps, over and over.

Ava: Please tell me this story has a good ending.

Andrew: It does, but it took him eight bad months. He is still at the workshop. He almost never draws now. He visits clients.

Ava: Visits them? Doing what?

Andrew: A client calls and says, we need shelves for the storage room. So Efren drives over, stands in the room, and finds the real problem.

Ava: And the real problem is never shelves.

Andrew: It is never shelves. In April a bakery ordered twelve of them. Efren measured the door first. The door was too narrow, by four centimetres.

Ava: So the shelves would have arrived and stayed in the street.

Andrew: Beautifully drawn, and useless. He had to come up with something else, so he designed one that folds flat and goes in sideways. Nobody asked him for that.

Ava: The program would never have measured the door.

Andrew: The program does not know there is a door. And Efren told me something I keep thinking about. He said, I look forward to Mondays now, and I never did in eleven years.

Ava: Fine. That is one happy cousin. I still think most of us are next in the queue.

Andrew: You might be right. But the people who guess about this have a terrible record.

Ava: Such as?

Andrew: Two thousand sixteen. Geoffrey Hinton, one of the biggest names in the field, said we should stop training radiologists. Within five years, he said, computers would read medical scans better than any human.

Ava: And the radiologists?

Andrew: Ten years later there are more of them working than there were then, and hospitals are still saying they need more.

Ava: Wait, seriously? More?

Andrew: More. He has admitted since that the timing was wrong. The machines got very good at one narrow slice of the work. The rest of the job did not go anywhere.

Ava: One wrong prediction does not make me feel safe.

Andrew: No, it should not. But look at what else we got wrong. Cash machines. When they arrived, everybody said bank tellers were finished.

Ava: They were finished.

Andrew: In the United States the number of bank tellers went up for about forty years after the cash machine arrived.

Ava: That cannot be right. I would have bet money the other way.

Andrew: Branches got cheaper to run, so banks opened more of them, and the people behind the counter stopped counting money and started talking to customers.

Ava: Okay. I was completely sure that number went down, and I was wrong.

Andrew: Now turn it around. Which job feels safe and is not?

Ava: A friend of mine checks invoices against delivery notes. Office, badge, screen, coffee at ten. It feels like the safest chair in the building.

Andrew: And it is the same six steps every morning.

Ava: Every morning. Hers might disappear the way Efren's did. Quietly. No announcement.

Andrew: She is likely to get a new job description one morning, without ever asking for one. And the tools will probably change again in five years. Efren will still be there, because he is the one who notices the door.

Ava: You know what, that has calmed me down a little. You have not calmed down at all, have you.

Andrew: Honestly, no. I have been telling this story for ten minutes and I still cannot answer the obvious question. If my work vanished next March, what would I do on the Tuesday?

Ava: I do not know either. I keep asking myself which part of my week nobody could copy. Some weeks the list is short.

Andrew: Mine too. If somebody typed my whole week into a table, what would fall out the bottom?

Ava: Ask me on the Tuesday.

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Ava: My father is sixty-eight years old. He owns exactly one belt. And last Sunday he pointed at my leggings and said the word athleisure.

Andrew: He did not.

Ava: Full sentence. Perfect pronunciation. I nearly dropped my coffee on the dog.

Andrew: Welcome to In the Lab FM. Your father does not follow fashion. He caught a word.

Ava: That is what gets me. Somebody says a word once, and a year later my father has it.

Andrew: And you can hear how that one was made. Athletic and leisure, squashed together with the middle cut out.

Ava: Brand new, too. Twenty fifteen, twenty sixteen. Everybody flying to the beach in gym clothes.

Andrew: That is what I thought. Then I looked it up last night. The oldest printed example in the dictionary is from nineteen seventy-six.

Ava: Wait, seriously?

Andrew: Nineteen seventy-six. Before the running shoes. Before the yoga.

Ava: So I have been telling everyone athleisure is brand new, and it is older than I am. Fine. I was wrong. Say the year again slowly so I can suffer properly.

Andrew: Nineteen seventy-six. The word sat there and waited for the rest of us to catch up.

Ava: Alright. Now the one I cannot forgive. Normcore.

Andrew: You really hate that word.

Ava: It sounds like a part inside a washing machine. Sir, your normcore is broken, that will be two thousand pesos.

Andrew: It has a proper birthday, though. Some trend forecasters in New York put it in a report in twenty thirteen. A year later it was in every magazine.

Ava: Plain jeans and a grey sweatshirt, and everyone treats it like a movement.

Andrew: My friend Ana paid three thousand pesos for a grey sweatshirt that looks exactly like my old school gym one. She is delighted with it.

Ava: My uncle Beto has dressed like that his whole life and nobody ever wrote a report about him.

Andrew: Nobody paid him, either. Okay, now my favourite. My cousin Teo has a tiny clothing brand in San Julian. Three people and one very loud sewing machine.

Ava: What does he make?

Andrew: He buys dead curtains from hotels and turns them into jackets. Upcycling. Which I now say about everything, and I cannot stop. On Saturday I told my neighbour I had upcycled a chair. I glued a leg back on.

Ava: You glued a leg.

Andrew: I upcycled a leg.

Ava: Upcycling is not old at all, by the way. A German engineer, Reiner Pilz, used it in an interview in nineteen ninety-four, and he was complaining. He said the recycling around him just smashed good things into worse things. He wanted the opposite.

Andrew: So he built it out of two pieces he already had lying around. Up. Cycling.

Ava: And then there is fast fashion, which is not built at all. Two ordinary words standing next to each other, holding hands. Together they mean something enormous.

Andrew: That one came from a newspaper. The New York Times, at the start of the nineties, about a shop that went from a sketch to a shelf in fifteen days.

Ava: Fifteen days. The fashion industry used to work in seasons. Four a year.

Andrew: Now some companies put out new things every week. The name is the most honest part of fast fashion. Everything after it is worse.

Ava: How does Teo compete with that?

Andrew: He does not. He sells about eleven jackets a month and every one of them used to be a curtain.

Ava: Can I tell you where I first met my father's word? Not from him. From a wall. My first job had a printed dress code next to the door. Closed shoes. No jeans. A tie for the men.

Andrew: And now?

Ava: My sister works in that same building. The dress code now says smart and comfortable. That is the whole thing. Half the floor is in athleisure and nobody looks twice.

Andrew: The clothes won, and then the rules changed to agree with them.

Ava: Here is what I keep wondering. Twenty years from now, which of these words is still alive? Does somebody in twenty forty-six say normcore and get a nod?

Andrew: Normcore dies. It was a joke about one moment, and the moment finished.

Ava: No. Normcore survives, and I will hate every year of it. Useless words hang on the longest.

Andrew: You want it dead so badly that you cannot see it straight. Fast fashion survives too, sadly, because the thing it describes is not going anywhere. Upcycling stays as well. Teo needs one word instead of four sentences.

Ava: Athleisure I am less sure about. It might quietly turn into clothes. That is the best way for a word to die. It wins so completely that nobody needs it.

Andrew: So the words we laugh at today are the boring ones our children will use for normal things.

Ava: And somebody is inventing the next one right now, this week. We will all be saying it by March, and none of us will remember picking it up.

Andrew: I still want to know who taught your father that word.

Ava: I am asking him on Sunday.

Andrew: Call me the second he tells you.

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Ava: I once cleaned the inside of my washing machine with a toothbrush. At one in the morning. The day before a big report was due.

Andrew: With a toothbrush.

Ava: My own toothbrush. That is the part I am not proud of.

Andrew: This is In the Lab FM. I am Beto, she is Ana, and she cleans machines that clean things.

Ava: Your turn. And not the polite version.

Andrew: Fine. Three years ago I got a parking ticket in Guadalajara. Four hundred pesos. I put off paying it for eleven months.

Ava: Eleven months.

Andrew: By then it was almost two thousand pesos, and I had to deal with an office, a long queue, and a very calm woman who asked me why I had waited.

Ava: What did you tell her?

Andrew: That I had been busy. She looked at the date on the ticket and said nothing. That silence cost me more than the fine.

Ava: Mine is quieter and worse. Every Sunday for three months I promised myself I would get down to writing one chapter.

Andrew: And?

Ava: And I would end up sorting my photos by colour. Blue folder, green folder. Three months of that. The chapter is still sitting there, like a small angry pet.

Andrew: I keep saying I will catch up on my email at the weekend. Then the weekend arrives already full of last weekend.

Ava: What I cannot work out is why the small jobs are the worst. The ticket. The dentist. Two minutes each.

Andrew: The dentist, yes. I have not been since two thousand twenty two. I mean to get around to it about once a week, and then I do not.

Ava: So what is going on in our heads? There is that famous study, is there not. The children and the sweets.

Andrew: Walter Mischel. Stanford, around nineteen seventy. They sat a small child at a table, put one marshmallow in front of him, and said, I am going out for a while. If it is still here when I come back, you get two.

Ava: How long is a while?

Andrew: About fifteen minutes. When you are four years old, that is half a lifetime.

Ava: And what did they do?

Andrew: Everything. Some ate it the second the door closed. Others covered their eyes, sang to themselves, turned the chair to the wall, kicked the table leg. Mischel wrote about children stroking the marshmallow like a small animal and still not eating it.

Ava: Stroking it.

Andrew: Like a hamster. And years later, the ones who waited were doing better at school and on tests. So there it is. Willpower at four decides your whole life.

Ava: No. That part fell apart.

Andrew: It did not. I have read that study in three different books.

Ava: The books are old. In two thousand eighteen a team led by Tyler Watts ran it again, with more than nine hundred children and a much wider mix of families.

Andrew: Nine hundred. Mischel had what, ninety?

Ava: About that. And once you take the parents' income and education into account, the effect gets small. Much smaller than the story we all repeat.

Andrew: How small?

Ava: Small enough that waiting at four tells you very little on its own. And here is the part that stays with me. The waiting may say more about the child's home. If food is reliable, and adults keep their promises, waiting is a sensible bet.

Andrew: And if adults have broken promises before, eating it now is also sensible.

Ava: It is the smart move, not the weak one.

Andrew: I have told that story at dinner parties for years. With the wrong ending. I hate that.

Ava: You can carry on telling it. Just change the ending.

Andrew: My mother used to say, dream big. And I did. One January I was going to learn the guitar, run a half marathon and read forty books.

Ava: How did that go?

Andrew: I own a guitar. I gave up on the books in February, around book three.

Ava: That is my problem with big plans. They feel wonderful at midnight and impossible at eight in the morning. So I cheat. I break it down until the first piece is stupidly small. Open the file. Write one bad sentence.

Andrew: That sounds like cheating.

Ava: It is cheating. It also works.

Andrew: Mine is stranger. My desk is where I check my phone, so I take the laptop to the kitchen counter and stand up. I cannot stand for more than half an hour, so things get finished out of pure discomfort.

Ava: You have built a small prison out of a kitchen. And now you are going to say something wise. I can feel it coming.

Andrew: It has a coffee machine, and no. I do not give up on things, Ana. I just put off giving up until Monday.